



PROG7313_ POE_PART1 Planning and Design

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POCKET WATCHERS

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Contents

Introduction.....	3
Planning and Design: Overview of the Pocket Watch App	4
Pocket Watch — App Requirements.....	5
Landing Page	5
Register Page.....	5
Login Page	5
Dashboard.....	5
Categories Page.....	5
Expenses Page	6
Budgets Page.....	6
Goals Page	6
Reports Page	6
Rewards Page.....	7
Info Page.....	7
Navigation & Design	7
Data Storage	7
Pocket Watch— UI Documentation	8
Pocket Watch — Screen Navigation Diagram	25
Project Plan	26
 Pocket Watcher Gantt chart.xlsx	26
Conclusion	27
References	28

Introduction

This design document builds on the findings from the previous research phase, which analysed three existing budgeting applications: Monny, Wallet: Budget & Money Manager, and You Need A Budget (YNAB). The research identified several useful features, including structured budgeting methods, financial insights, and user engagement strategies that support effective money management (BudgetBakers, n.d.; SingSaver, 2025; YNAB, n.d.).

Using these insights, this phase focuses on the design of the **Pocket Watch App**, a proposed mobile budgeting application aimed at helping users track their spending, plan budgets, and develop better financial habits. This document outlines the planned features, functionality, and design approach of the application, providing a clear foundation for the development of the prototype.

Planning and Design: Overview of the Pocket Watch App

The **Pocket Watch App** is a proposed mobile budgeting application designed to help users monitor their spending, plan budgets, and improve their financial habits through a clear and accessible platform. The design of the app is informed by research conducted on three existing budgeting applications: Monny, Wallet: Budget & Money Manager, and You Need A Budget (YNAB), which highlight the importance of structured budgeting, financial insights, and user engagement in effective money management (BudgetBakers, n.d.; SingSaver, 2025; YNAB, n.d.).

The app's visual identity is represented through a mascot-based icon that reflects the concept of "watching over" a user's money. The icon features a pocket watch mascot sitting inside a green pocket while holding money, symbolising the idea of keeping track of what is happening in a user's pocket. The mascot uses blue and yellow, which form the main colour theme of the application, while the design also connects to the group name Pocket Watchers, reinforcing the purpose of helping users watch their spending.

Key features of the **Pocket Watch App** include a structured budgeting system inspired by YNAB's zero-based budgeting method, which allows users to allocate income to categories such as groceries, transport, entertainment, and savings (YNAB, n.d.). The app will also provide a visual financial dashboard displaying balances, spending summaries, and remaining budget amounts using charts and visual indicators (BudgetBakers, n.d.). To encourage regular engagement, the application includes gamification features such as progress tracking, milestone achievements, and reward badges inspired by Monny (SingSaver, 2025). In addition, the app supports financial goal tracking, allowing users to set savings targets or spending reduction goals and monitor their progress over time.

Overall, the **Pocket Watch App** combines structured budgeting tools, visual financial insights, and engaging design elements to create a practical mobile solution that supports both daily expense tracking and long-term financial awareness.

Pocket Watch — App Requirements

Landing Page

- On install, an animated onboarding sequence plays where the Pocket Watch mascot's speech bubbles show relatable budgeting problems (e.g. "Where did all my money go?") followed by how Pocket Watch solves it. Shown once only on install — inspired by YNAB's onboarding flow. (Store, 2024)
- After onboarding (or if skipped), the Landing Page shows the icon, app branding, and "Get Started"/"Sign In" buttons.

Register Page

- 'Get started' takes the user to the registration page where the user will **register** with a unique username, password (with confirmation).

Login Page

- Users **log in** with username and password. Invalid credentials show a specific error. Already logged-in users are auto-redirected to the Dashboard.

Dashboard

- Shows a personalised welcome, **monthly budget summary** (budget, spent, remaining, **level and XP progress card**, and the 5 most recent expenses.
- Lists all **categories** with spending, budget limit, and a red overspending warning where applicable.
- **Shortcut buttons** to add an expense and add a category.

Categories Page

- **Four default categories are auto-created** (Groceries, Transportation, Utilities, Healthcare).
- Users create and **edit categories**, each with a name and either a preset palette colour or custom uploaded icon, inspired by the Wallet App (BudgetBakers, 2025). An optional monthly limit can be set per category. Creating a category awards 15 XP.
- **Category cards** show icon/colour, name, total spent, expense count, progress bar, and a red highlight when overspent.
- Each category card has an **"Add Expense"** button opening the expense form, where users add expenses with an amount, date (defaults to today), description and a optional receipt photo. A thumbnail shows on the entry;

tapping opens a full-screen viewer. The Add Expense form is also accessible from the Dashboard and category cards.

- **Deleting a category** is blocked if expenses are linked to it — those expenses must be reassigned or deleted first.

Expenses Page

- All **expenses are listed** in reverse chronological order with category badges and receipt thumbnails for the users viewing.
- Users can **filter by category or date** range and delete entries (deletion requires confirmation).

Budgets Page

- Users set a **monthly spending goal/limit**. A **live calculation** shows total allocated vs. overall budget with an over-allocation warning. Saving awards 25 XP and updates the Dashboard immediately.
- **Colour-coded status**: green/yellow at 80%/red when exceeded the monthly spending limit.
- Individual **limits** can be set **per category**. Categories exceeding their limit are highlighted in red.
- A "Roll With the Punches" note explains that overspending in one category is acceptable if balanced elsewhere.(Feature inspired by YNAB app) (YNAB, 2024)

Goals Page

- Users create **savings goals** with a name, target amount, saved amount, and deadline. Each card shows a **progress bar, percentage complete**, and a contribution **history button** listing every deposit made. Goals are colour-coded green, yellow, or red based on how on-track the user is. Completing a goal triggers a celebration animation and awards 100 XP.
- Users can **delete goals**.
- Users can pin important goals
- A goal history archive (coming) will be added in a future update.*

Reports Page

- Displays visual analysis of spending **over a user-selected date range** using three chart types : a **daily bar chart** showing spending per day colour-coded by category, a **weekly trend line chart** showing spending patterns over time, and a **category donut chart** showing the distribution of spending across categories. All charts **include interactive tooltips**. Users can toggle between daily, weekly, and monthly views.

- A **summary card** shows total spending and daily average. Includes comparison tools to **view spending across different time-periods**.
- An **export option** to download reports is coming in a future update.*
- A category breakdown shows total spending per category for any selected period.

Rewards Page

- Pocket Watch includes a gamification system to make budgeting engaging. Users **earn XP** points through actions across the app — logging an expense, creating a category (15 XP), contributing to a goal etc. Accumulated XP increases the user's **level**, which progresses across 10 named levels.
- The current User level is displayed in the top nav and sidebar at all times. The Rewards Page shows the user's level name and number, total XP, and a progress bar to the next level. (Greamer Co, 2025)
- Eight collectible badges are earnable through specific milestones (e.g. First Expense, Goal Getter, Receipt Master etc). Earned badges display in colour with the date earned; locked badges appear in greyscale.
- A **points breakdown guide** lists every way to earn XP.
- Inspired by the Monny app's level-based reward system. (Greamer Co, 2025)

Info Page

- Includes a 5-step getting started guide, key features overview, pro tips, and an 8-question FAQ in dropdown format covering adding expenses, gamification, "Roll With the Punches", and data storage.

Navigation & Design

- A persistent top nav bar shows the app name and **logout button**.
- On mobile, **a bottom bar** covers the four main pages and **a hamburger menu** accesses the rest. The app has a consistent blue colour scheme.

Data Storage

- All data — accounts, expenses, categories, budgets, and goals — will be stored in an online database for cross-device access. The app handles connectivity issues with clear error messaging.
- Deleting an expense immediately updates all related totals without a page refresh.

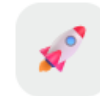
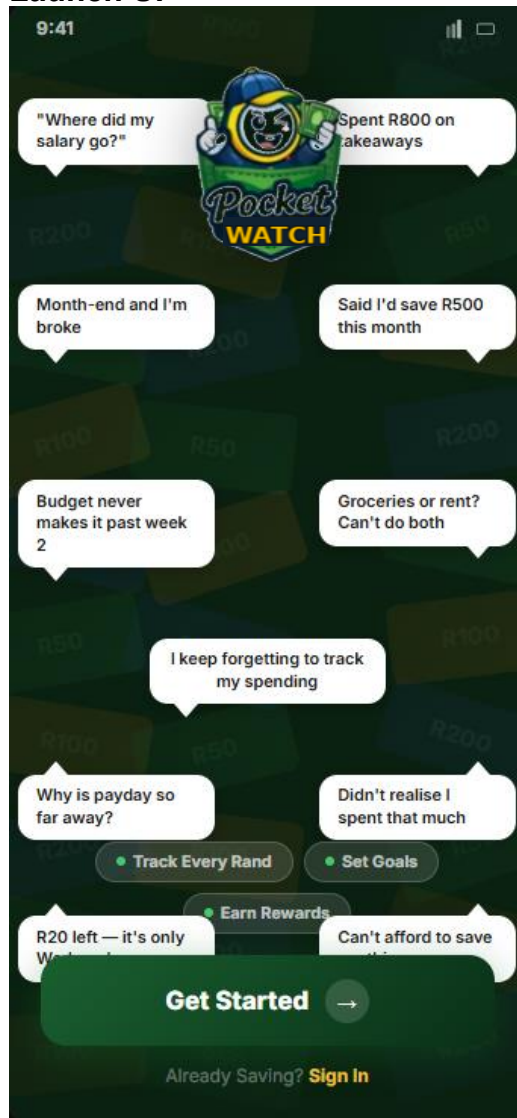
Pocket Watch— UI Documentation

HCI Principles Applied: Feedback, error recovery, consistency, minimal memory load, and flexibility — each screen is designed around at least one Nielsen usability heuristic (Cloud, 2025).

User-Centred Design: Every screen was designed around what a young South African first-time budgeter needs to do, not what is technically convenient to build (Holost, n.d.).

Usability Focus: Bottom navigation keeps core actions always visible. Progress bars and live totals give constant feedback without overwhelming the user.

Launch UI



AUTH

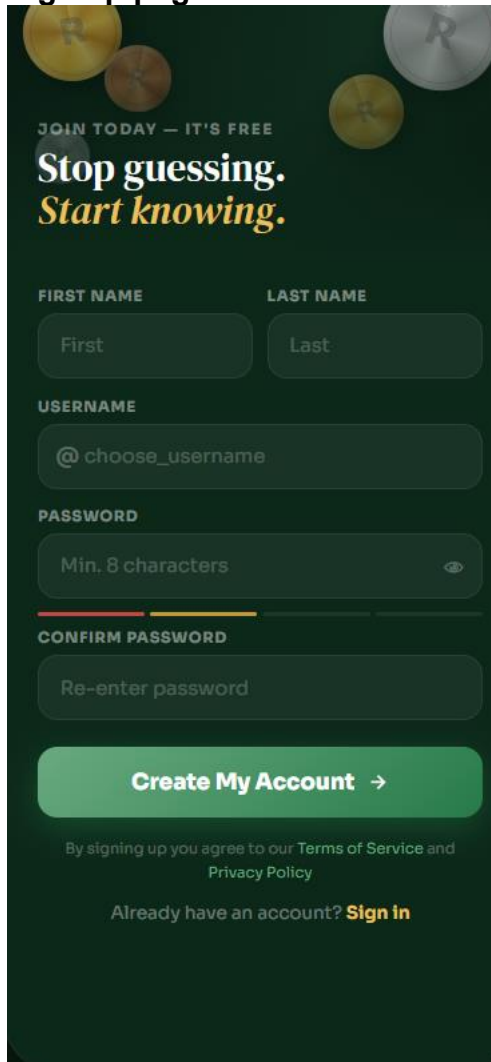
Launch Page

The first screen a user sees. Its sole job is to communicate what the app does and give two clear paths — sign up or sign in. Speech bubble will continuously pop up relating to financial struggles to encourage user to 'Get Started'. Minimal content removes cognitive load and builds a good first impression .

FIRST IMPRESSION

2 ACTIONS ONLY

Sign up page



JOIN TODAY — IT'S FREE

Stop guessing. *Start knowing.*

FIRST NAME LAST NAME

First Last

USERNAME

@ choose_username

PASSWORD

Min. 8 characters

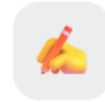
CONFIRM PASSWORD

Re-enter password

Create My Account →

By signing up you agree to our [Terms of Service](#) and [Privacy Policy](#)

Already have an account? [Sign in](#)



AUTH

Sign Up Page

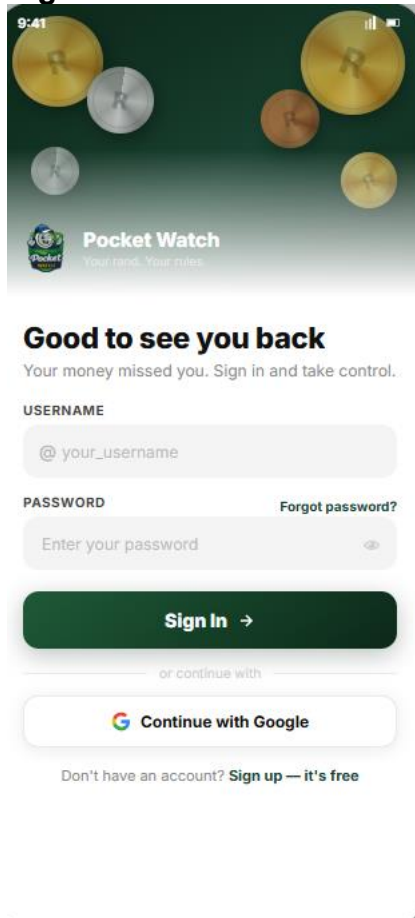
Collects only what is necessary to create an account — name, username, password. Username-based login (not email) reduces the barrier to entry and aligns with how South African youth identify online.

PROGRESSIVE DISCLOSURE

USER-CENTRED FIELDS

MINIMAL INPUT

Sign In



9:41

Pocket Watch
Your rand. Your rules.

Good to see you back
Your money missed you. Sign in and take control.

USERNAME
@ your_username

PASSWORD [Forgot password?](#)
Enter your password

Sign In →

or continue with

 **Continue with Google**

Don't have an account? [Sign up — it's free](#)



AUTH

Sign In Page

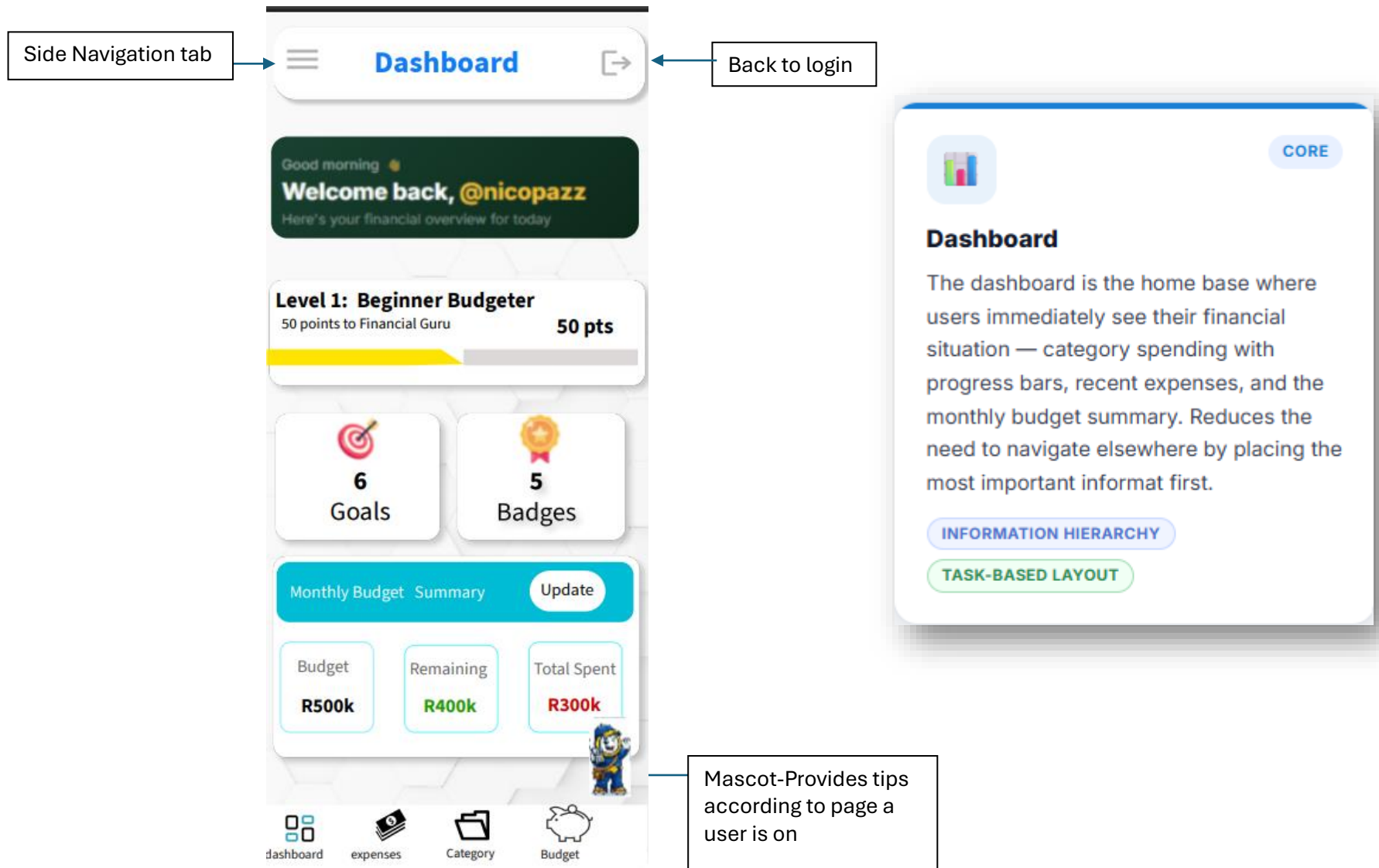
Returns existing users to their account quickly.
Username + password with a visible forgot-password link supports error recovery — a core HCI principle ensuring users are never stuck.

ERROR RECOVERY

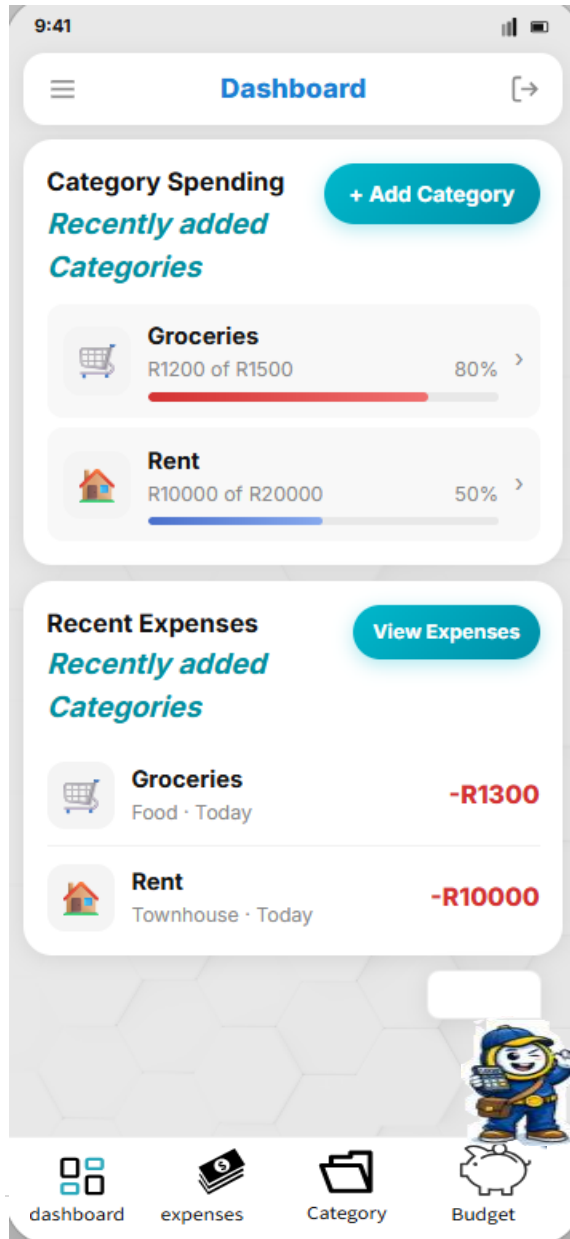
RETURNING USER FOCUS

FAST RE-ENTRY

Dashboard

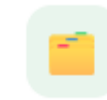
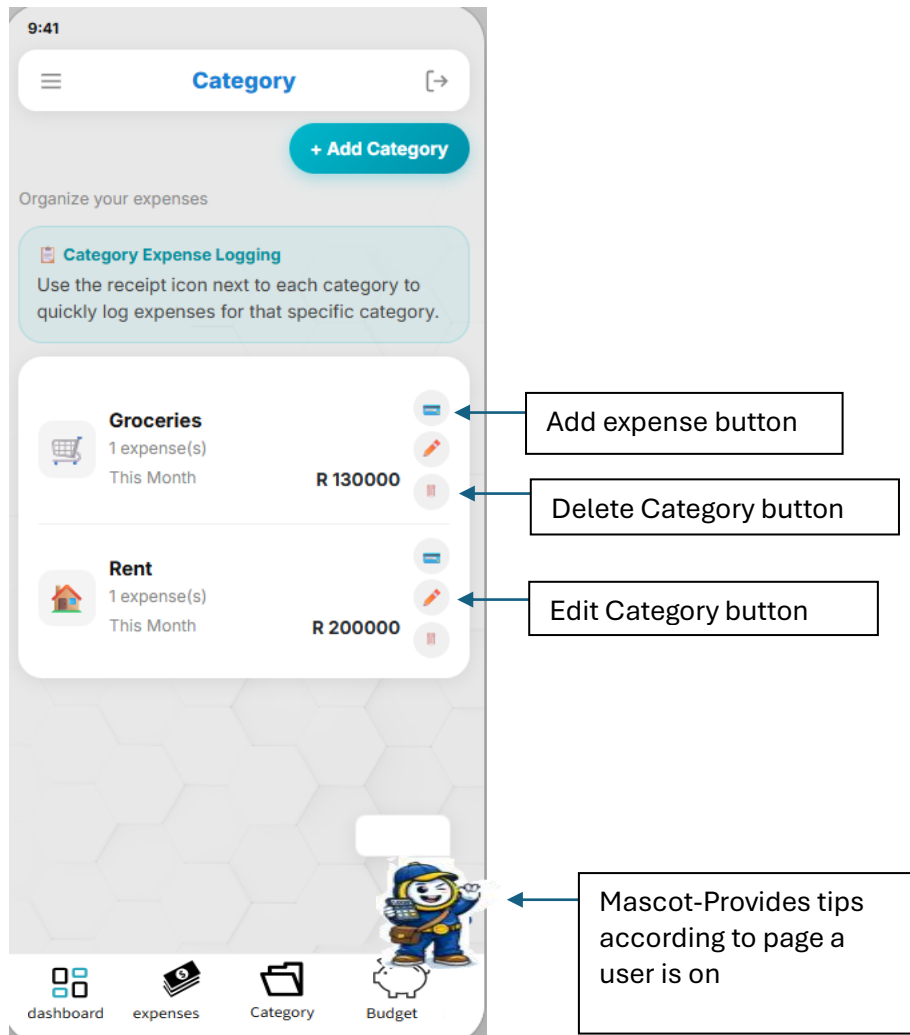


Continuation of Dashboard



Mascot-Provides tips according to page a user is on

Category



CORE

Category

Lets users organise their spending into named categories. Colour coding or icons creates visual chunking — a proven HCI technique for quick recognition. Each category shows monthly spend total, giving instant feedback on spending patterns. For each category a user can has an option to update, delete and add an expense.

VISUAL CHUNKING

COLOUR RECOGNITION (COLOUR AND ICON OPTION)

9:41

Add Expense

Add New Category

Create a new expense category

CATEGORY NAME *

e.g., Groceries, Entertainment

CATEGORY COLOR

+ Add Icon

MONTHLY BUDGET LIMIT (OPTIONAL)

R0.00

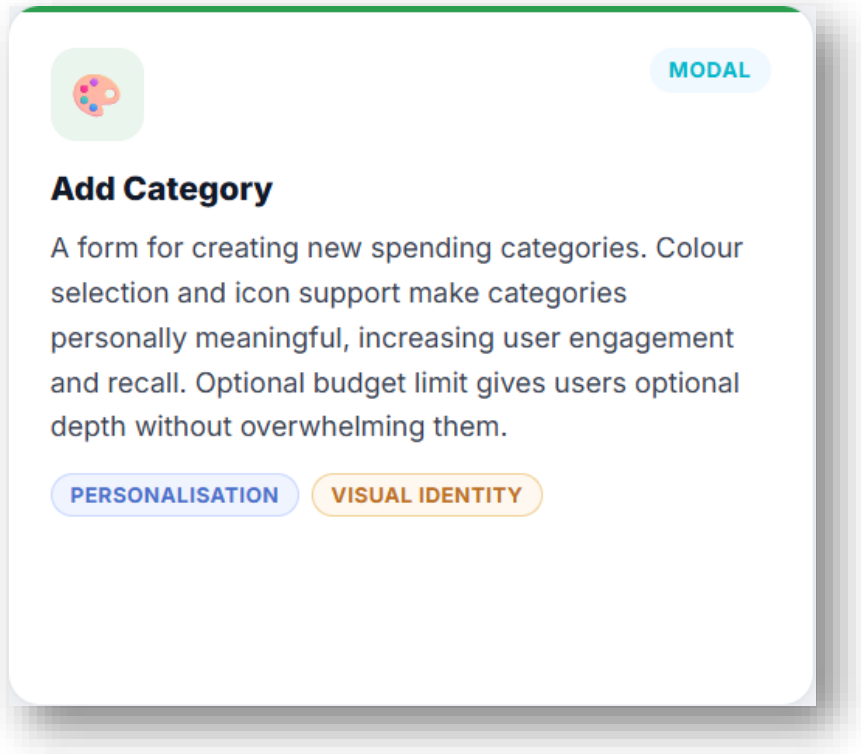
+ Add Category

dashboard

expenses

Category

Budget



Expense Form

9:41

Add Expense [→]

Add Expense to Groceries ×

Log an expense for this category

AMOUNT *

200

DATE *

2026/03/13

DESCRIPTION *

Food

RECEIPT PHOTO (OPTIONAL)

Upload a photo

Add Expense

dashboard expenses Category Budget



MODAL

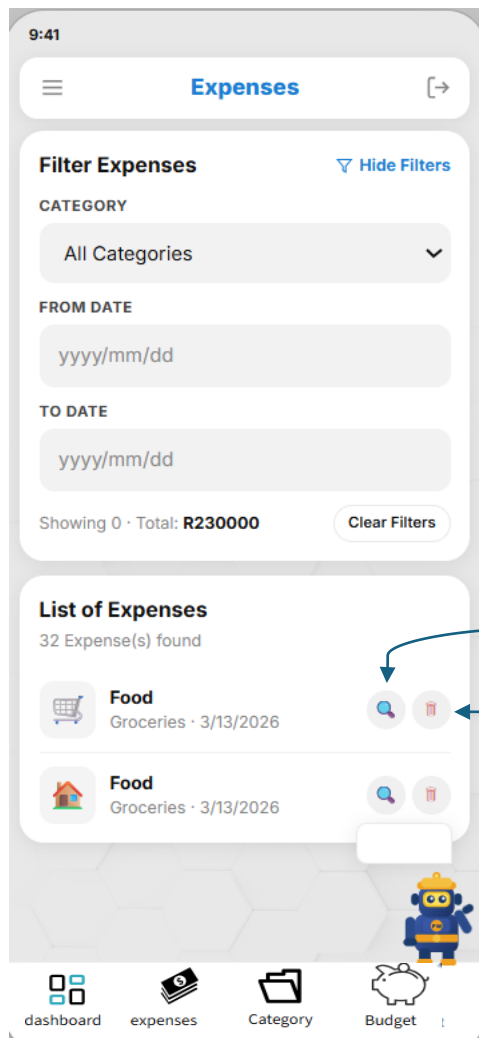
Add Expense

A Form sheet that captures a single expense. Fields are ordered logically (amount → date → description → photo). User can add an expense for a specific Category but clicking on that category in the Category page.

REDUCED MANUAL INPUT

LOGICAL FIELD ORDER

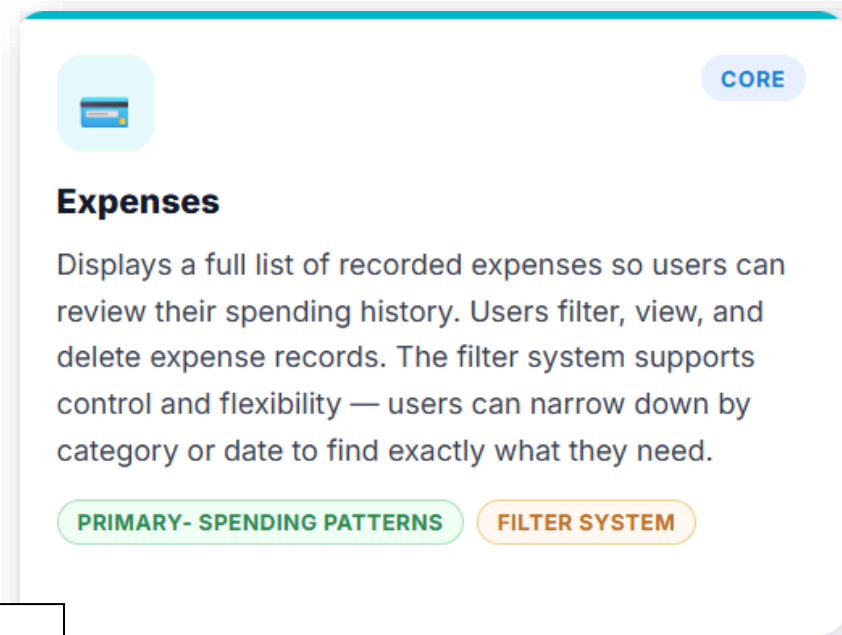
Expense Page



View Expense details button

Delete expense button

Mascot-Provides tips according to page a user is on



Budget page

9:41

Budget

Budget wisely

Set your monthly spending limit

Monthly Budget *

R1000.00

Category Budgets

Set individual spending limits for each category (optional)

Groceries	R 200.00
Rent	R 0.00
Transport	R 0.00

Total Monthly Budget: R1000.00

Allocated to Categories: R200.00

Unallocated: R800.00

Mascot-Provides tips according to page a user is on

dashboard expenses Category Budget

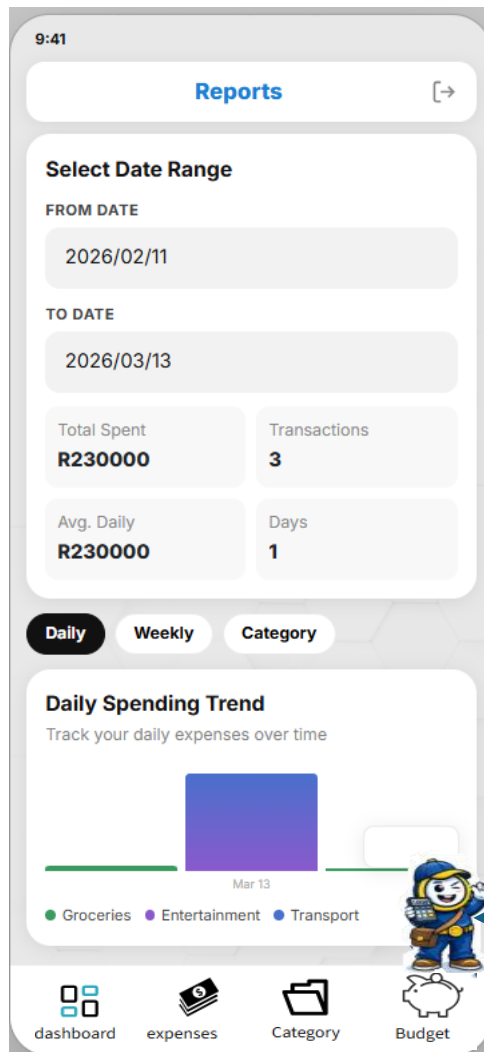
Budget

Empowers users to set a monthly spending budget and allocate amounts per category. The live unallocated amount gives immediate feedback as the user types, reducing errors and supporting informed decisions — a key usability practice.

IMMEDIATE FEEDBACK FINANCIAL AUTONOMY

LIVE CALCULATION

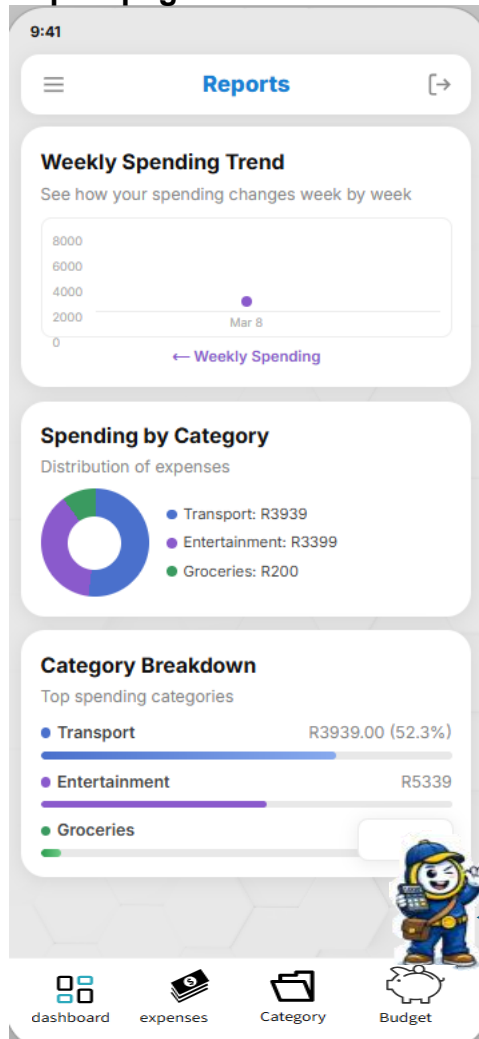
Report Page



Mascot-Provides tips according to page a user is on

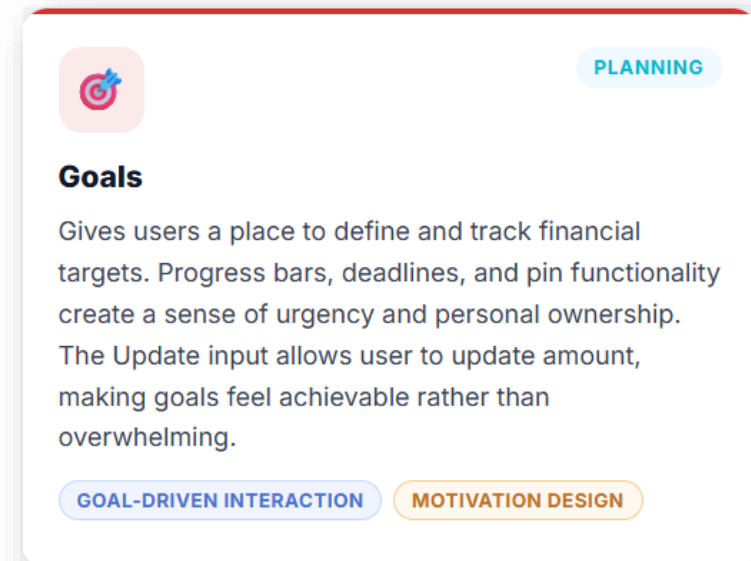
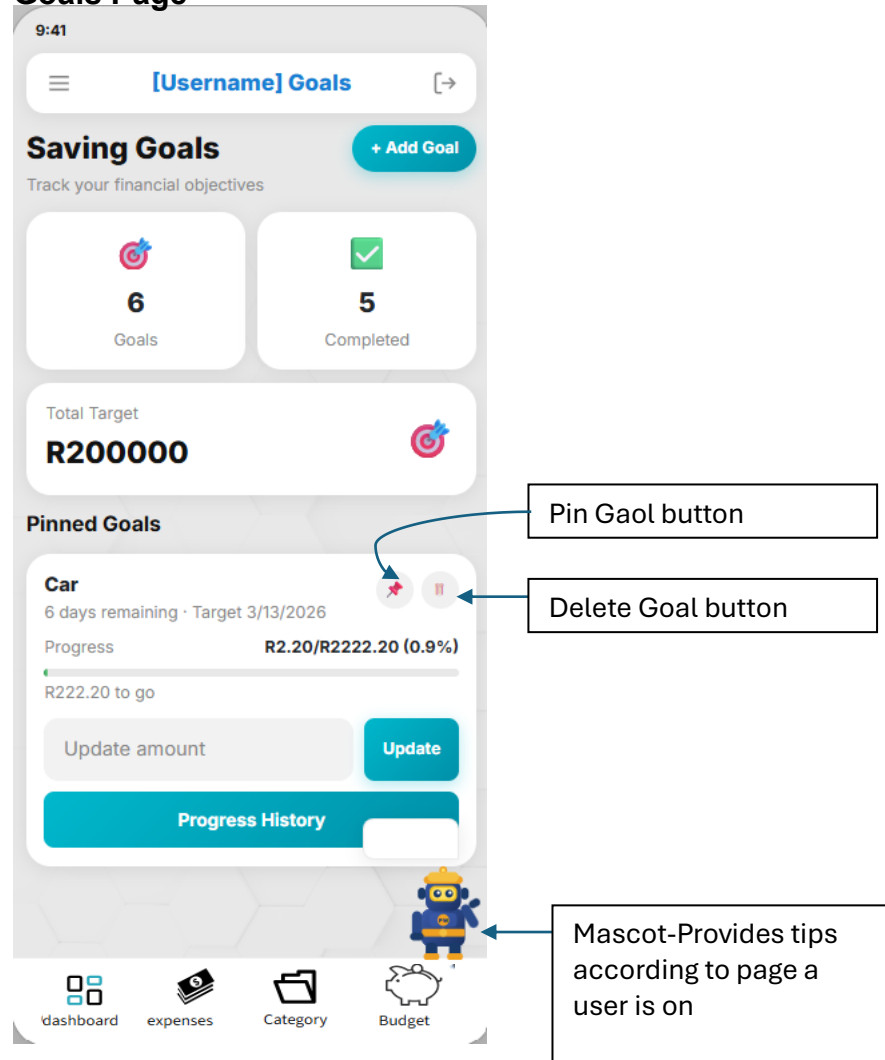
The insight card has a purple header and a light blue 'INSIGHT' label. It features a line chart icon. The title 'Reports' is in bold. The text describes the feature: 'Transforms raw expense data into visual insight — bar charts, pie charts, and category breakdowns. The Daily / Weekly / Category toggle reduces the need to scroll to view graphs a core UCD principle.' At the bottom are two buttons: 'DATA VISUALISATION' (blue) and 'IDENTIFY PATTERNS' (orange).

Report page continuation

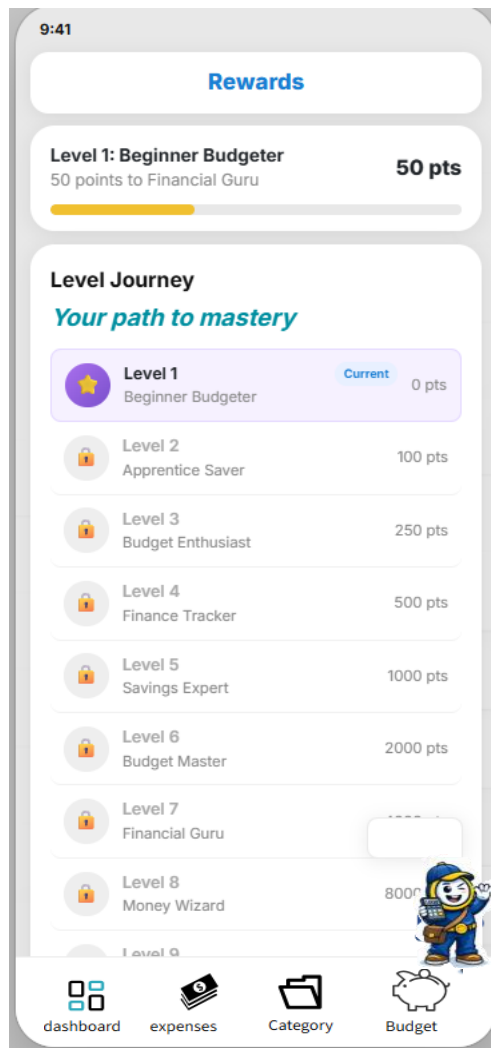


Mascot-Provides tips according to page a user is on

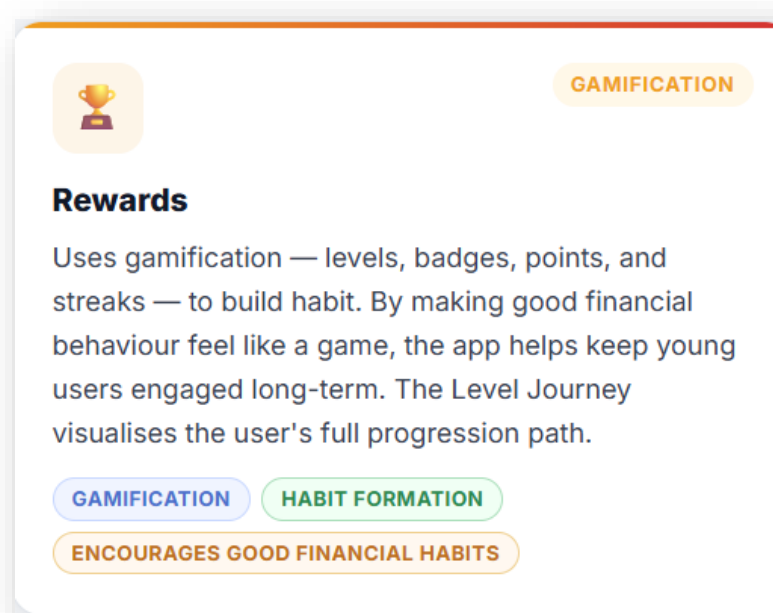
Goals Page



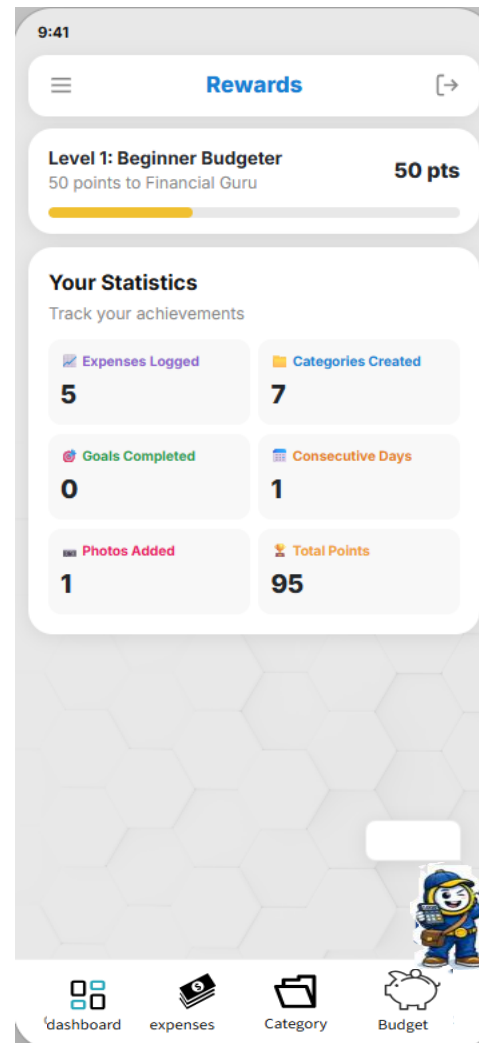
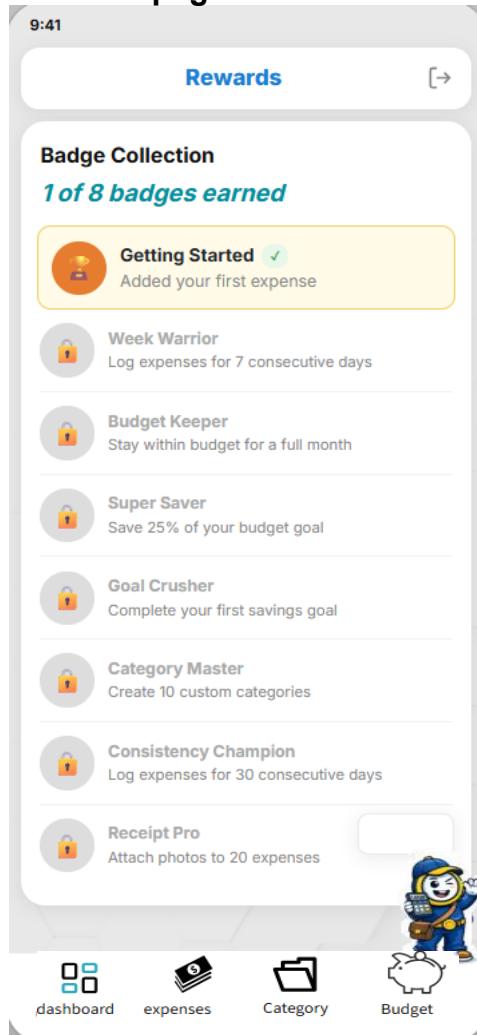
Rewards page



Mascot-Provides tips according to page a user is on

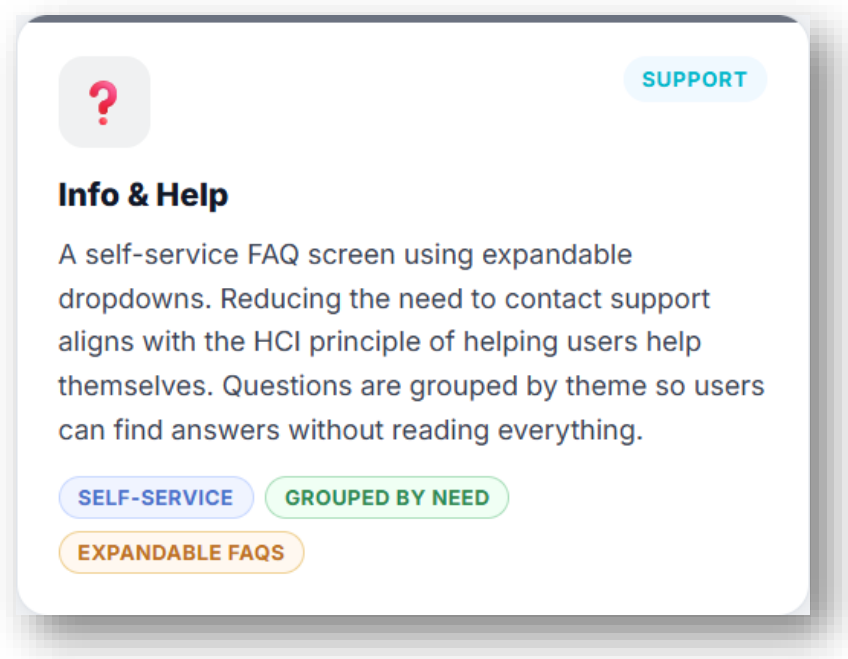
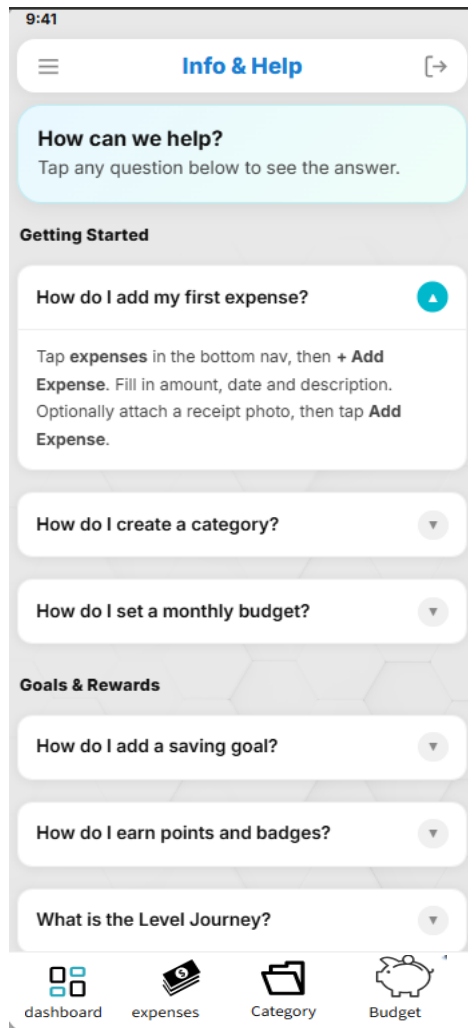


Rewards page continuation



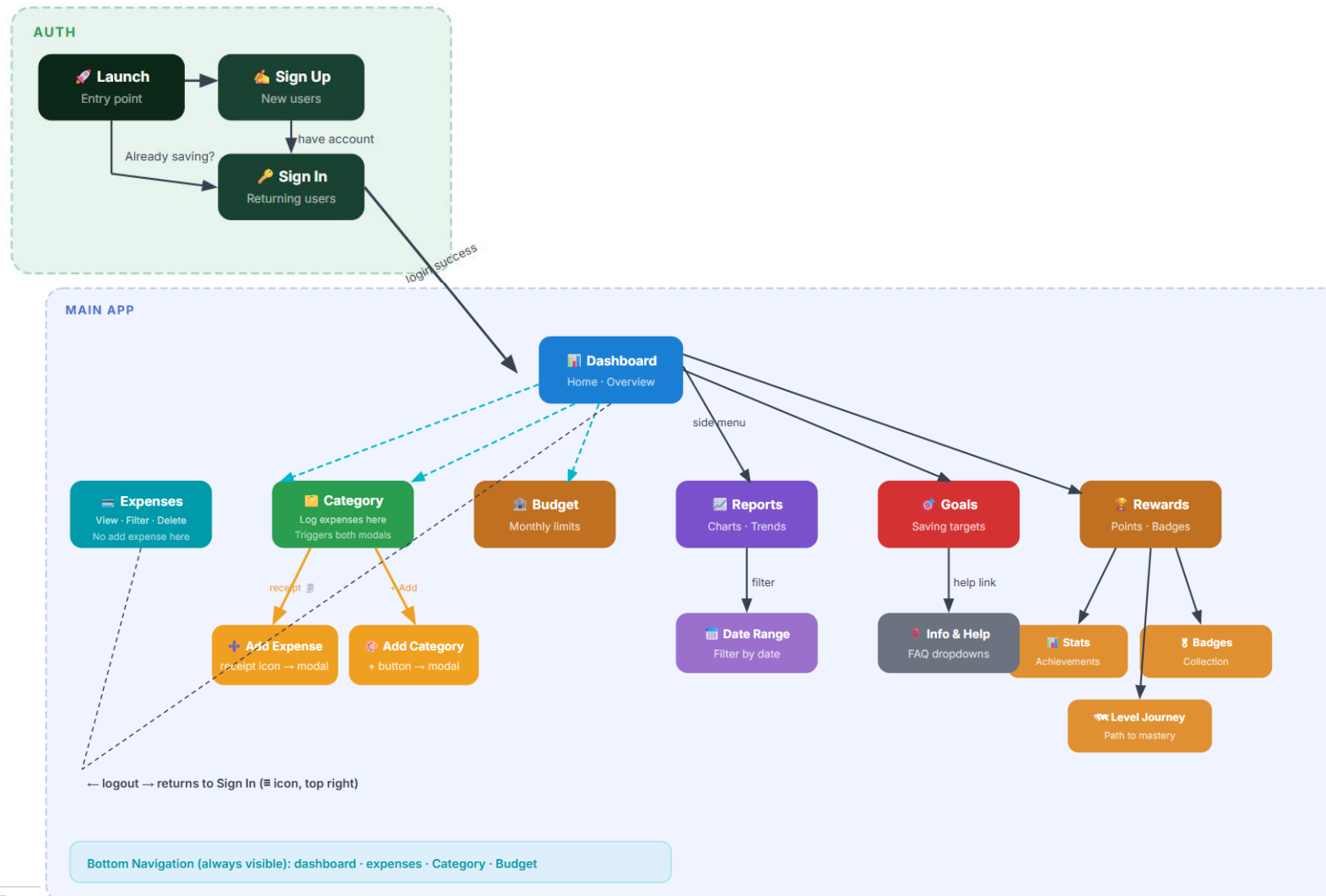
Mascot-Provides tips according to page a user is on

Info and Help



Pocket Watch — Screen Navigation Diagram

Arrows show how users move between screens. Solid = direct navigation. Dashed = bottom nav access. Gold = form/modal overlay.



Project Plan



Pocket Watcher Gantt
chart.xlsx

Conclusion

The design of the **Pocket Watch App** was informed by research on existing budgeting applications such as Monny, Wallet, and YNAB, which highlight the importance of structured financial planning, clear financial insights, and engaging user experiences in effective budgeting tools (BudgetBakers, n.d.; SingSaver, 2025; YNAB, n.d.).

Based on these insights, the Pocket Watch App integrates features such as structured budgeting categories, visual dashboards, spending analytics, and motivational elements that encourage consistent financial tracking. Together, these design decisions provide a strong foundation for developing a practical and user-friendly budgeting application that supports improved financial awareness and decision-making.

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